

CyberSafe AI — Cybersecurity FAQ Knowledge Base

50 beginner-friendly questions and answers covering essential online safety topics

Password Security

Q: What is a strong password?

A: A strong password is at least 12 characters long and mixes uppercase, lowercase, numbers, and symbols. Avoid common words, names, or birthdates.

Q: How often should I change my passwords?

A: Change passwords immediately if a service reports a breach. Otherwise, every 6-12 months for sensitive accounts is reasonable if you use unique passwords everywhere.

Q: Should I reuse passwords across sites?

A: No. Reusing passwords means one leaked password can compromise all your accounts. Use a unique password for every account.

Q: What is a password manager?

A: A password manager is an app that securely stores and generates strong, unique passwords for all your accounts, so you only need to remember one master password.

Q: Is it safe to write passwords down on paper?

A: It's safer than reusing weak passwords, but a password manager is much more secure and convenient for most people.

Two-Factor Authentication (2FA)

Q: What is 2FA?

A: Two-Factor Authentication adds a second verification step (like a code sent to your phone) in addition to your password, making accounts much harder to hack.

Q: Should I enable 2FA on all my accounts?

A: Yes, especially for email, banking, and social media. Even if your password is stolen, 2FA can stop attackers from logging in.

Q: What is an authenticator app?

A: An authenticator app (like Google Authenticator) generates time-based codes for 2FA, which is more secure than receiving codes by SMS.

Q: Is SMS-based 2FA safe?

A: It's better than no 2FA, but SMS can be intercepted via SIM-swapping attacks. An authenticator app or hardware key is more secure.

Phishing & Email Scams

Q: What is phishing?

A: Phishing is when attackers send fake emails, texts, or messages pretending to be a trusted source to trick you into revealing personal information or clicking malicious links.

Q: How can I identify a phishing email?

A: Look for urgent language, spelling errors, mismatched sender addresses, generic greetings, and suspicious links. When in doubt, contact the company directly through official channels.

Q: What is spear phishing?

A: Spear phishing is a targeted phishing attack aimed at a specific person or organization, often using personal details to appear more convincing.

Q: What should I do if I clicked a phishing link?

A: Disconnect from the internet, run an antivirus scan, change your passwords immediately, and monitor your accounts for suspicious activity.

Q: What is an SMS scam (smishing)?

A: Smishing is phishing conducted through text messages, often claiming a package delivery issue, prize, or urgent account problem to trick you into clicking a link.

Q: Should I ever share an OTP with someone?

A: Never. A One-Time Password should never be shared with anyone, even someone claiming to be from your bank or a delivery service.

Social Engineering

Q: What is social engineering?

A: Social engineering is manipulating people into revealing confidential information or performing actions that compromise security, rather than hacking technical systems.

Q: How do scammers build trust quickly?

A: They often impersonate authority figures, create urgency, or pretend to already know you, pressuring you to act before you think carefully.

Q: What is pretexting?

A: Pretexting is when an attacker creates a fabricated scenario (like posing as IT support) to trick you into giving up sensitive information.

Malware & Viruses

Q: What is malware?

A: Malware is malicious software designed to damage, disrupt, or gain unauthorized access to a computer system.

Q: What is the difference between a virus and a worm?

A: A virus needs a host file and human action to spread, while a worm can self-replicate and spread across networks without user interaction.

Q: What is a Trojan horse?

A: A Trojan is malware disguised as legitimate software. Once installed, it can give attackers access to your system.

Q: What is spyware?

A: Spyware secretly monitors your activity, such as keystrokes or browsing habits, and sends that data to an attacker without your knowledge.

Q: What is ransomware?

A: Ransomware encrypts your files and demands payment for the decryption key. Regular backups are the best defense against ransomware.

Q: How can I avoid downloading malware?

A: Only download software from official sources, avoid pirated content, keep your antivirus updated, and don't click suspicious links or attachments.

Wi-Fi & Network Safety

Q: Is public WiFi safe to use?

A: Public WiFi is risky because attackers on the same network can intercept your data. Avoid logging into sensitive accounts on public WiFi unless using a VPN.

Q: What is a VPN?

A: A Virtual Private Network encrypts your internet traffic and hides your IP address, making it much safer to browse on public or untrusted networks.

Q: Should I use my home router's default password?

A: No. Always change the default admin password on your router, since default credentials are widely known and easily exploited.

Q: What does HTTPS mean?

A: HTTPS means the connection between your browser and the website is encrypted. Always check for HTTPS, especially on login or payment pages.

Safe Browsing

Q: How can I identify a fake website?

A: Check the URL spelling carefully, look for HTTPS, check for poor grammar or design, and verify through a search engine if the site seems suspicious.

Q: Are QR codes safe to scan?

A: Not always. Malicious QR codes can lead to phishing sites or trigger downloads. Only scan QR codes from trusted sources.

Q: What is a browser extension risk?

A: Some browser extensions can track your activity or inject malicious code. Only install extensions from trusted developers with good reviews.

Q: Should I save my card details on shopping sites?

A: It's more convenient but riskier if the site is breached. Only save card details on well-known, reputable sites with strong security.

Social Media & Privacy

Q: How can I secure my Facebook account?

A: Enable 2FA, review your privacy settings regularly, avoid accepting requests from strangers, and be cautious about what personal info you share publicly.

Q: How can I secure my Instagram account?

A: Use a strong unique password, enable 2FA, make your account private if needed, and be wary of unsolicited direct messages with links.

Q: How can I secure my Gmail account?

A: Enable 2FA, use a strong password, review connected apps regularly, and check your account activity for unfamiliar logins.

Q: What is a digital footprint?

A: Your digital footprint is the trail of data you leave online through posts, searches, and activity. Minimizing oversharing helps protect your privacy.

Q: Should I accept friend requests from strangers?

A: Be cautious. Fake profiles are often used for scams or to gather your personal information for social engineering attacks.

Identity Theft & Data Breaches

Q: What is identity theft?

A: Identity theft occurs when someone uses your personal information, like your name or ID numbers, without permission, usually for financial gain.

Q: What is a data breach?

A: A data breach is when a company's systems are compromised and sensitive user data is exposed or stolen.

Q: How do I know if I was part of a data breach?

A: You can check breach notification services or your email provider's security alerts to see if your accounts were involved.

Q: What should I do after a data breach?

A: Change your passwords immediately, enable 2FA, monitor your accounts and bank statements, and watch for phishing attempts referencing the breach.

Antivirus & Software Updates

Q: Do I really need antivirus software?

A: Yes, antivirus software helps detect and block malware, though safe browsing habits are equally important.

Q: Why are software updates important?

A: Updates often patch security vulnerabilities that attackers could exploit. Delaying updates leaves your devices exposed.

Q: Should I enable automatic updates?

A: Yes, automatic updates ensure you receive security patches as soon as they're available, reducing your exposure to known vulnerabilities.

Data Backup & Cloud Security

Q: Why is backing up my data important?

A: Backups protect you from data loss due to ransomware, hardware failure, or accidental deletion.

Q: What is the 3-2-1 backup rule?

A: Keep 3 copies of your data, on 2 different types of storage media, with 1 copy stored offsite or in the cloud.

Q: Are cloud storage services secure?

A: Reputable cloud providers use strong encryption, but you should still use a strong password and enable 2FA on your cloud account.

USB & Device Safety

Q: Is it safe to plug in an unknown USB drive?

A: No. Unknown USB drives can contain malware designed to infect your device automatically. Avoid plugging in unfamiliar USB devices.

Q: Should I lock my devices when not in use?

A: Yes, always lock your phone and computer with a PIN, password, or biometric lock to prevent unauthorized physical access.

Cyber Hygiene

Q: What is cyber hygiene?

A: Cyber hygiene refers to the regular practices and habits, like updating software and using strong passwords, that keep your devices and data secure.

Q: What is the easiest way to improve my online safety today?

A: Enable 2FA on your most important accounts and start using a password manager. These two steps offer the biggest security improvement for the least effort.